

terest him anymore. Pretty good for a child who spent his school years at Bombay Scottish in the bottom three of the class, drank his father's after shave and had to be rushed to hospital to have his stomach pumped and spent two years of HR College in Mumbai "bumming around and doing the bad things kids do when they're suddenly given freedom". His mother, former actor Neetu Singh, recalls that she was called to school every year between Class I and Class XII, either because he had looked up a teacher's skirt forcing her to forever wear saris or dropped his pants. "At HR College, his attendance was 2 per cent. Can you believe that?" she says laughing. Slackers of the world can rejoice.

Ranbir would always watch the first day first show of every film with

"The days of slow motion hero shots and romancing a woman on the cliff are long over."

his mother right through college. It was a given that he would take to the family business, as it happens in most Bollywood film dynasties, where retaining the father's stardom is ingrained in the DNA. But rather than be paralysed by the expectations, Ranbir applied to the School of Visual Arts in New York ("because it had a colourful website," he says facetiously) where he made student films, watched world cinema and learnt to live on his own, surviving on a budget, washing the dishes and doing the laundry. Three years on, he went to

The Lee Strasberg Theatre and Film Institute, where he studied for a year, and lived in the East Village. "That's what gave him this alternative head space," says Karan Johar, pointing out that it makes him gravitate towards arthouse cinema as easily as mainstream potboilers. When he came back, armed with a cv and determination, he asked Sanjay Leela Bhansali for a job as an assistant on *Black*. He got it. "I was getting beaten up, abused, doing everything from cleaning the floor to fixing the lights from 7 a.m. to 4 a.m., but I was

VISVANATHAN www.indianexpress.com

Kapoor likes women and, well, they like him. He's been linked with practically every girl he's worked with. Here he is on four of them:

DEEPIKA PADUKONE

Bachna Ae Haseeno

"A wonderful old soul. Has shown only 10 per cent of what she's capable of. It's unfair to ask why we broke up. But I'd like to think we could become friends and work together in future."

SONAM KAPOOR

Saawariya

"She's a child at heart. Unpredictable. But there's no malice in her. She's not too ambitious or competitive. She's just in the moment."

KATRINA KAIF

Ajab Prem ki Ghazab Kahani and Raajneeti

"She's just the coolest girl ever. She's always criticising me, my hair, my physique. She's very intelligent, doing so well despite the language barrier. She's a friend for life."

PRIYANKA CHOPRA

Anjaana Anjaani

"She's extremely intelligent. She's blended spontaneity and technicality. You don't have to work hard with someone like her. You just have to react."



THE SINGLE Life

YOGEN SHAH

FOTOCORP

FOTOCORP

GETTY IMAGES